

Public Open Review in Practice

Experiences from the Living Handbook on Discrimination-Sensitive Metadata Practice

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ABSTRACT

This transcript-led lecture script presents practical lessons from the public open review of a living handbook on discrimination-sensitive metadata. It examines versioning, annotation tools, reviewer recruitment, moderation, psychological safety, and the institutional work required to sustain an open publication.

KEYWORDS

public open review, open peer review, living handbook, discrimination-sensitive metadata, scholarly communication, digital public history

Core message. Openness does not replace invitation, enablement, or moderation - and a living handbook does not live by itself.

Editorial note: This polished version follows the sequence and emphasis of the delivered talk. The preparatory guide was used only to verify names, dates, figures, and technical terminology.

Extended abstract

This contribution examines the practical conditions under which public open review can improve a scholarly publication. It draws on the revision of *Discrimination-Sensitive Metadata Practice*, a living handbook developed from the work of the public-history project Stadt.Geschichte.Basel. The handbook originated in a concrete curatorial problem: how should historical images, objects, descriptions, and research data be published when they reproduce racist or sexist classifications, depict vulnerable people, or document histories of violence? Because existing guidance did not adequately address the project team's needs, Moritz Mähr and Noëlle Schnegg produced a first edition, commissioned technical and content reviews, and published it as an openly accessible living handbook.

The living-handbook model promised continuous improvement through public feedback. In practice, however, it created tensions among openness, version stability, citability, and editorial responsibility. The first edition remained the stable, DOI-bearing publication, while a substantially rewritten second edition was made available separately as a preview. Reciprocal notices directed readers between the two versions. This arrangement preserved a citable edition while exposing the revision to review, but it also made the status of the publication difficult to communicate. The case demonstrates that a living handbook is not simply a document format. It is an ongoing publication and maintenance commitment involving versioning, moderation, technical infrastructure, editorial decisions, and institutional responsibility.

The review used a combination of Quarto, GitHub, Hypothes.is, and Zenodo. Together, these systems made source changes, discussions, annotations, and releases visible. Yet they did not constitute a review procedure. GitHub presented a technical and social barrier for many intended participants; feedback often arrived by email because contributors were reluctant to identify errors publicly. A private Hypothes.is group was established to provide a protected review environment, but reviewers were unable to join it and instead annotated the public page. The resulting public export contained 52 annotations from three people, all of whom had been invited personally. Elias Zimmermann contributed 38 annotations, Mario Kliewer 13, and Peggy Große one. Thus, 51 of the 52 annotations came from two reviewers. The review was substantively productive, but the anticipated broad, self-organizing participation did not materialize.

The most consequential stage was a moderated Zoom conversation on 7 November 2025 involving the three reviewers, Noëlle Schnegg, and Moritz Mähr. The meeting allowed participants to move beyond local annotations and discuss structural interventions: chapter order, missing material, conceptual distinctions, and the balance between theory and practice. It also supported clarification and prioritization before the authors established a revision timetable. This synchronous exchange supplied context and interpersonal feedback that public annotation threads could not provide. It was especially important because the handbook addresses discrimination, racism, and antisemitism. Immediate public attribution may inhibit provisional or critical comments, particularly when contributors are personally implicated in, or directly affected by, the subjects under discussion.

The case therefore distinguishes technical openness from social accessibility. Publicly reachable tools distribute the possibility of participation, but they do not create responsibility, recognition, confidence, or time. Reviewers require a specific invitation, a clearly bounded task, relevant questions, realistic deadlines, accessible tools, and onboarding. They also need permission to develop and revise their judgments. A system that records every preliminary thought publicly can create pressure to be correct from the outset, even though reviewing is itself an iterative intellectual process.

For future editions, the contribution proposes a model of invited review with delayed disclosure: a public call for reviewers, selection and personal invitation based on relevant expertise, a clearly versioned manuscript, an initially protected review environment, and a moderated discussion that consolidates major questions. The authors should document how each recommendation was accepted, modified, or rejected. With the participants' consent, the completed reviews, author responses, and editorial decisions should then be published alongside a stable edition with a DOI and clear citation guidance. Public post-publication comments may continue, but they should be distinguished from the formal review. The central conclusion is not that public open review failed. It improved the handbook, but it succeeded through invitation, enablement, moderation, and editorial labor rather than through openness alone.

0:00 Begin with the revised handbook

On screen. *Open the current revised handbook and point to the publication information, revision notice, and link to the stable edition.*

I want to begin with the book itself. As you can see, we have published the revised version. The URL is not especially easy to cite or remember, but in a way that already reflects the provisional status of the handbook: we have not yet minted a DOI for this revision.

The page shows both a publication date and a date when it was last changed, and those dates are slightly out of sync with the actual history. We published the first version earlier, then carried out a substantial reworking. The handbook is a moving target. We call it a living handbook, but once a publication is changing continuously, even a simple question such as its publication date becomes difficult to answer.

There is a reference here to the last officially published version, which is easier to cite. But the new version does not only have a different title. Large portions of the book have changed. We tell readers that the revision is ongoing, that this is a living handbook, and that we invite continuous feedback. Still, the result is a little messy.

I think that messiness is not accidental. Maintaining a living handbook means managing several things at once: an audience, a technical infrastructure, the content itself, and a discussion about that content. In our case, those things live on different platforms. Some friction is therefore almost inevitable.

3:00 Return to the origin: Stadt.Geschichte.Basel

On screen. *Open the first-edition documentation from the Stadt.Geschichte.Basel project. Then show a conventional digitized image record.*

Let me dial this back and return to the beginning of the first version. Stadt.Geschichte.Basel was a large public-history project on the recent history of the city and canton of Basel-Stadt. It ran for roughly nine years. I was responsible for the project's digital work: open-access publication of the books, preparation of research data, maps, and other digital artifacts produced by my team.

Among those tasks, we wanted to publish the figures used in the books wherever we could clear the rights. Many records were straightforward. You have an image, a description, and information about the rights situation. For material like that, the publication workflow is relatively clear.

On screen. *Move through examples of sensitive material: racist or sexist imagery, children shown in troubling contexts, and the branding instrument.*

But other material was not straightforward at all. Some images were racist or sexist. Some showed children in troubling or ambiguous situations. Even an object that looks like a piece of equipment can carry a violent history. This instrument, for example, was used to brand people. That raises an immediate question: is it responsible simply to place such material online, where school classes and many other audiences may encounter it without context?

My colleague Noëlle Schnegg and I began looking for best practices. In 2023, we could not find guidance that answered our practical questions. So we decided to develop it ourselves: a handbook for working with discriminatory and sensitive metadata in public-history projects.

We contacted many institutions and colleagues - including the Swiss National Museum, the ETH archives, and others whom we expected to face similar problems. We quickly learned that there was a real need. Many people in galleries, libraries, archives, and museums wanted practical guidance, but little was available.

7:30 The first edition and the decision to keep it living

We wanted to write the handbook collaboratively with other institutions. But our project timetable was short, and potential partners were understandably hesitant to commit to it. Our funding would eventually run out, so we needed a usable result quickly.

We therefore wrote the first draft ourselves and commissioned a closed review. It included both technical and content review. After incorporating that feedback, we published the first edition.

We deliberately presented it as a living handbook. We were certain that we had missed things. We also knew that needs and answers would vary depending on institutional context, collection history, and the communities involved. So we wanted to open the continuing discussion around the handbook, not treat the first edition as the final word.

10:00 GitHub was open, but email felt safer

On screen. *Open the GitHub repository and the discussion containing corrections and additions after the first publication.*

We published the handbook's source files on GitHub. GitHub is normally associated with software development. It is a rather technical place, and we knew that would be a barrier for many of the people we hoped to reach. Nevertheless, we opened a discussion forum for corrections and additions.

Some useful exchanges did happen there. For example, a colleague from the Plakatsammlung Basel told us that we had cited one example incorrectly, and other people joined the discussion. We also received detailed comments on issues such as GND semantics and keyword indexes.

But most people did not post their criticism directly on GitHub. They wrote us an email. Part of the reason was technical: GitHub is difficult to approach if you are not a software engineer or a data scientist. But I think the more important reason was social. Most people do not feel comfortable pointing out someone else's mistakes in public.

Whenever someone sent useful feedback by email, we asked whether we could copy it into the public discussion. That allowed the conversation to become visible, but it also showed us that public documentation and a psychologically safe first contact are not the same thing.

13:30 Rewriting the handbook while preserving a citable edition

On screen. *Show the stable first edition and the preview of the second edition side by side, including the reciprocal callout boxes.*

Eventually it became clear that we needed to rewrite the handbook almost completely. We decided to conduct that rewrite as publicly as possible. We closed the earlier discussion, opened a new one, and published the emerging second edition at a different address.

The reason for separating the pages was citation. We wanted readers to be able to cite a stable edition with a DOI. At the same time, we needed reviewers to work with the new version. That combination creates a practical problem: the audience must still be able to reach the handbook, but ideally they should read the new version rather than the old one - while also understanding that the new version has not yet completed review.

Our solution was to place a prominent notice on the new site: this is a preview of the revised handbook; if you need the stable version, follow this link. On the old site, we placed the inverse notice. It was not a particularly sustainable arrangement, but it did help many readers find the new edition.

Getting people to the page, however, was easier than getting them to engage with the content.

16:30 Hypothes.is: a good annotation tool that still needed onboarding

On screen. *Open Hypothes.is, show the browser annotation sidebar, and demonstrate a public annotation on the handbook.*

For the open review, we chose Hypothes.is. It is a web-annotation platform that allows readers to highlight a passage and attach a comment directly to it. With the browser extension installed, a sidebar appears beside the page. Users can collect annotations in an account and choose between public and private annotation contexts.

We created a private group called Review Handbook. We shared the link and explained how to log in, because we wanted reviewers to have a protected space. Unfortunately, nobody managed to join that private annotation group. That was a real disappointment. The safe space we had designed technically did not work socially or practically.

Instead, most reviewers annotated the public page. Here, for example, is an annotation by Elias Zimmermann, who works on the Annemarie Schwarzenbach edition at the University of Zurich. The interaction itself is elegant: select text, annotate it, or simply highlight it. I still think it is a very good technical solution.

But it needs onboarding. We cannot assume that people will install an extension, create an account, understand groups and privacy settings, and then review a full handbook without clear instructions and support.

19:30 What the numbers actually showed

On screen. *Show the public export or summary: 52 annotations from three people; 51 of the 52 came from two people.*

In the end, we collected 52 public annotations. They came from three people, and all three were reviewers whom we had personally invited. Elias Zimmermann contributed 38, Mario Kliewer 13, and Peggy Große one. So the review was intensive, but it was not broad or self-organizing.

The attractive idea behind an open knowledge commons is that anyone can contribute and that a wider community will help review the work. Our experience was more modest. Substantial review still required

identifiable people doing real work. That work takes time, and the question of recognition matters.

People need to be invited. They need to hear that their expertise is specifically wanted and that they are the right people for the task. Unless a community already has a strong culture of open reviewing, meaningful participation does not simply appear because a comment button is available.

Deadlines were another difficulty. Open review periods often have deadlines, but those deadlines are easily understood as soft: contribute whenever you have time. After several months, we scheduled a call with the reviewers. Interestingly, even these personally selected experts tended to begin their reviews shortly before the call.

That is very human. Academic life contains many tasks for which people are formally paid and many forms of valuable labor that happen on top of them. Unpaid reviewing is often postponed until the latest possible moment. A concrete meeting created the urgency that an open-ended invitation did not.

22:30 The moderated conversation did the editorial work

On screen. *Open the public record of the 7 November 2025 Zoom discussion and the consolidated revision plan.*

On 7 November 2025, Peggy Große, Elias Zimmermann, Mario Kliewer, Noëlle Schnegg, and I met for a one-hour Zoom conversation. We documented that discussion publicly on GitHub.

The call made it possible to raise larger questions about the book: should the chapters be reordered? Should a chapter be removed? Was an entirely new chapter needed? Those are substantial requests. People often hesitate to post them online without context.

A conversation adds a human layer. You can explain why a suggestion matters, ask clarifying questions, and sense whether a request is too broad or too disruptive. We used the call to consolidate the annotations, identify priorities, and agree on a timeline for the final revision. That synchronous, moderated step was extraordinarily useful.

It also made me more cautious about the promise of public open review, especially for sensitive topics such as discrimination, racism, and antisemitism. There can be a high barrier to having your name permanently associated with these discussions online.

For someone like me - a white cis man speaking about discrimination - that visibility can create one kind of discomfort and uncertainty. For someone who is directly affected by the discrimination under discussion, it can create another and potentially much more serious risk. After this experience, I am not convinced that an immediately public environment provides enough safety for every part of the review.

25:00 The systems were not the procedure

There is a second lesson. Our toolchain did not prescribe a review procedure. GitHub, Quarto, Hypothes.is, and Zenodo can each make part of the process visible. But the tools do not decide who reviews what, how comments are discussed, how conflicts are resolved, or why an editorial suggestion is accepted or rejected.

A clear procedure is the alpha and omega of the whole process. Only with explicit roles, stages, deadlines, and decision rules can a review become genuinely transparent, as impartial as possible, and reproducible.

Looking back, I do not think we defined the procedure clearly enough at the beginning. We also expected too much from the idea of community-based open web review. We thought the public setup would attract more people. It did not, for the technical and social reasons I have described.

Some of the technical hurdles were unnecessary. Many reviewers would probably have felt more comfortable in a familiar environment such as Google Drive. A sophisticated open tool is not automatically the most accessible tool.

I still believe that reviewers benefit from seeing one another's observations. But I am less certain that every comment needs to become public while it is being written. People revise their thinking when they read other comments. If every preliminary thought is documented online under your name, you can feel pressure to be right the first time.

That is not what review should be. Review should be iterative. Reviewers, too, should have the right to be uncertain, to test an idea, and sometimes to be wrong before they arrive at a considered judgment.

27:00 What I would do differently

If we could do the process again, I would identify reviewers in advance and also publish a call so that additional experts could apply. I would still want the reviews to become public, because a public record adds real transparency.

But I would conduct the first phase in a protected space. Reviewers need room for clarification, disagreement, unfinished thoughts, and fundamental criticism. The authors then need to consolidate that material before publication.

Preferred model. A public call, a private review, and a public record.

In other words: invited review with delayed disclosure. The openness would lie in publishing the completed reviews, the authors' responses, and the editorial decisions - with the participants' consent - rather than requiring every first thought to be public at the moment it is formed.

28:15 The next publication step and closing

On screen. *Show Bielefeld University Press and the Digital Humanities Research series, then return to the handbook.*

We are currently working with Bielefeld University Press toward publishing the handbook as a printed and open-access book. The press needed to conduct its own reviews, including for an application for open-access funding from the Swiss National Science Foundation.

That publication will exist alongside the living handbook. We will try to continue developing the online version. But a living handbook is not only time-consuming editorial work. It is also infrastructure that must be

maintained, even if that maintenance consists only of moderating a GitHub discussion, preserving versions, and keeping links and systems working.

So my conclusion is not that public open review failed. The review improved the handbook. But it worked because specific people contributed expertise, because we created deadlines and a meeting, and because we moderated and consolidated the feedback. Public access made the process more visible; it did not replace the work required to make review happen.

Despite the cost, I still think this prototype - this whole endeavor - was worth it. I am curious to see where the handbook and its review model go next. And I am very grateful for the opportunity to present the case and think it through with you. Thank you very much.

Citation

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